The 1,386-km Delhi-Mumbai Expressway—at the centre of the government's highway push—was expected to be finished by October last year. By late 2025, the project had cost Rs 71,718 crore, making it one of the most expensive single road projects in India's history. In Parliament, Gadkari has admitted that his ministry has been grappling with delays on this, due to land acquisition problems, delayed permissions and complicated urban interfaces—challenges that have affected several other highway projects as well.

CLOSING GAPS

Gadkari describes the hurdles as systemic. "And systems have to be fixed," he says. Over the last couple of years, there have been efforts to tighten the grip. In April 2024, over 150 projects were delayed by more than three years. By December 2025, that number had dropped to under 90. Similarly, the bouquet of awarded projects awaiting appointed dates has nearly halved over the same period. On the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway, construction gathered pace. The 9-km DND junction-Jaitpur stretch in Delhi shows 95 per cent progress, and is slated for completion by June. Long stretches such as Sohna-Dausa-Lalsot are already operational. Owing to this expressway, Gurugram to Jaipur is now just a three-hour journey.

Officials credit the turnaround to a behind-the-scenes re-engineering. Land acquisition has been transferred to the Geographic Information System-mapped Bhoomi Rashi digital platform. After the clearance of General Financial Rules, the Parivesh app expedites forest clearances. Railway overbridge permissions, notorious for time sinks, are granted online. Local-level stuck projects are escalated through chief secretary-led state meetings and, if that doesn't work out, to the Project Monitoring Group or even the PM's PRAGATI (Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation) platform. Contracts are now being tightened. Design errors are penalised more aggressively. Persistently delayed packages are re-tendered.

While such moves have helped, the usual last-mile glitches remain on many stretches. Land access at the edges, utility shifting, late design tweaks and contractor underperformance can still derail progress. Gadkari has censured non-performing officials and consultants. J.P. Singh of AITWA points to another problem: "High toll rates add to the cost. In India, it is the highest. Add to that unauthorised 'toll' collections at many state borders, and many a time concessionaires are nowhere to be found when truckers need them in distress."

If these expressways open broadly on schedule, they will strengthen the case for Bharatmala's next phase and unlock greenfield industrial zones, potentially delivering a political dividend in a year of crucial state elections. They will also test whether India's road-building apparatus has finally learned to finish what it starts. ■

THE LAST MILE

Some key highway corridors, delayed for years, that will be completed by FY27

Amritsar Bypass (4)
●50 ●38 ●0
May 2026*

Beas-Mehta-Batala-Dera Baba Nanak (4)
●79 ●30 ●0
Dec. 2026*

Abohar-Fazilka Bypass (4)
●45 ●12 ●0
Apr. 2026*

Chandigarh-Ambala-Shamli (6)
●184 ●132 ●31
Dec. 2026*

Paniyala-Barodameo (6)
●87 ●0 ●0
Sept. 2026*

Delhi-Mumbai Expressway Delhi-Vadodara Section (8)
●912 ●900 ●697
Mar. 2026*

Delhi-Mumbai Expressway Vadodara-Mumbai Section (8)
●450 ●336 ●180
Mar. '27*

Indore-Hyderabad (4)
●527 ●469 ●375
Dec. 2026*

Mohali-Sirhind-Sehna (4)
●135 ●22 ●0
Mar. 2026* for 27 km awarded section

Ambala Ring Road (4)
●23 ●14 ●0
Sept. 2026*

Delhi-Saharanpur-Dehradun (6)
●264 ●250 ●48
Jan. 2026* for main carriageway (212 km), Jun. 2026 for Spur-Haridwar (51 km)

Kanpur-Lucknow Expressway (6)
●63 ●62 ●0
Mar. 2026*

Durg-Raipur-Arang (4)
●92 ●58 ●0
Aug. 2026*

Raipur-Ranchi (4)
●507 ●120 ●0
Aug. 2026* for 158 km of under-construction portion

Raipur-Visakhapatnam (6)
●465 ●430 ●0
Dec. 2026*

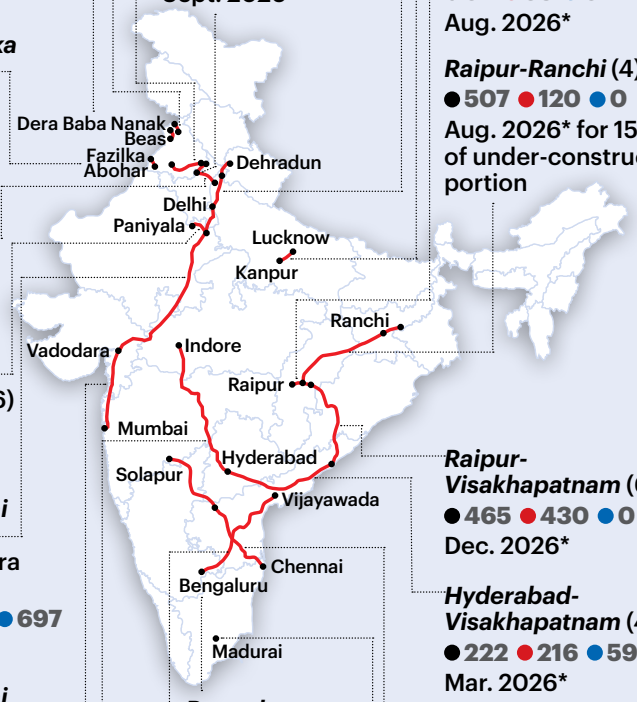
Hyderabad-Visakhapatnam (4)
●222 ●216 ●59
Mar. 2026*

Solapur-Kurnool-Chennai (4)
●290 ●212 ●0
Oct. 2026*

Madurai Ring Road (4)
●30 ●28 ●0
Apr. 2026*

Bengaluru Ring Road (6)
●280 ●128 ●80
Mar. 2026*

Bengaluru-Kadappa-Vijayawada (6)
●343 ●176 ●0
Feb. 2027*



●Total length (km) ●Constructed length (km) ●Length open to traffic (km); *completion timelines; number of lanes in ( ); figures are rounded off